



Future Formats

With DVD capturing everyone's fancy (even 'Digit' now offers a free DVD with its every issue), the amount of storage space it provides may seem more than enough. Eventually, even this space will fall short. Here's an example. HDTV broadcasts are already available for prime-time shows in the US and Japan. HDTV offers crystal clear picture quality, but takes up more space as compared to the DVD format. Hence, recording HDTV shows will need more space than a single DVD. This is where the new formats step in.

Blu-Ray

Blu-Ray technology was founded by a consortium of Hitachi, LG, Matsushita, Pioneer, Philips, Samsung, Sharp, Sony, and Thomson, with Mitsubishi joining them in 2003. Dell and HP recently announced their support for this standard. Sony's PlayStation 3 console will also support Blu-Ray disks. These disks offer a storage capacity of 27 GB per layer, and use a 405 nm blue laser to write data. Blu-Ray recorders have already started shipping in Japan. And yes, they are really expensive.

HD-DVD

Developed by Toshiba and NEC, an HD-DVD disk is similar to the current DVD, and stores 15 GB of data per layer per side. This technology also uses the same 405 nm blue laser to write data. Its biggest plus lies in its ability to use existing production lines for manufacturing processes. Toshiba and NEC have already announced plans to launch HD-DVD recorders next year. Microsoft too has announced native support for HD-DVDs in Windows Longhorn, which is slated for a 2006 release.

Choose a dual-format DVD-Writer. It may cost you more, but it lets you write to any type of media

while the same written at 8X takes around nine minutes—a difference of six minutes per DVD. If you get a lot of backups done, you may want to opt for a faster DVD-writer.

Format

Rewritable disks need to be formatted before they are used. DVD-RW disks do not support background formatting whereas DVD+RW disks do.

Therefore, opt for a DVD+RW disk when writing data on to a rewritable disk. Also, choose a dual-format DVD-writer, as it lets you write to any type of media, even if it costs more.

On the other hand, if you also want to write to DVD-RAMs, opt for a superdrive that lets you write to media of any format. At present, only Iomega manufactures superdrives.

Three Little DVDs Went to the Market

At Lamington Road, Mumbai's hardware heaven, Mitsubishi DVD+Rs were available for Rs 210 each, while a Pioneer DVD-Rs cost Rs 180. On the other hand, Imation and Moser-Baer offer both types of media for Rs 130 each, while Sony prices it at Rs 150.

Princo was the surprise. While a single DVD-R retails for Rs 38, a spindle of 10 costs a reasonable Rs 320. We did not find any dual-layered media.

Rewritable media were priced steeply: Mitsubishi's DVD+RWs retail at Rs 400 each and those from TDK Rs 375. As for DVD-RWs, we could just find some manufactured by Pioneer retailing at Rs 375.

Cheap variants of both formats are available for anything between from Rs 31 to Rs 110. ■

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